



[Course](#) > [4. Reporting your findings](#) > [4.4 Convincing your audience](#) > Word choices

Word choices

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Another aspect of convincing your readers of your modelling results, is to use an appropriate tone in your report. You are not having a friendly chat conversation. You are writing a scientific report, and the words you use, should be chosen accordingly.

In this section, we will focus on keeping your tone *formal* and *objective*. These concepts overlap significantly, but each has its own focus.

Objective language

The goal of a scientific report is to answer a scientific question, by means of a scientific argument. The feelings, opinions or experiences of its authors are irrelevant to this. This is why the language used in the report should be objective: an impersonal style of writing. To achieve this style, focus on the following aspects:

- Avoid the words "I" or "you" in the text. This places focus on the author or reader rather than the results. Using "we" is considered slightly better, but should still be avoided when possible.
Instead, you can try to shift the subject of the sentence to another word. Perhaps one of the other nouns can serve as a subject (often creating a passive sentence). Other options use the words "it" or "there" as subjects, or use "this research". The closest option to the subjective "I / you / we" is the use of "one".

Subjective: *We can conduct an experiment to test this hypothesis.*

Objective alternatives:

This hypothesis can be tested in the following experiment.

The following experiment can be conducted to test this hypothesis.

It is possible to test this hypothesis using an experiment.

There is an experiment that can test this hypothesis.

One can conduct an experiment to test this hypothesis.

- Avoid words reflecting opinions, experiences or feelings. Some first examples of

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- And finally, you should avoid explicitly giving opinions or talking about feelings in a scientific report. Only in a paragraph on motivations (in the introduction) might this be relevant.

Exercise A

1/1 point (graded)

 Keyboard Help

PROBLEM

Please determine which of the following words and phrases are objective, and which are subjective. Drag each word or phrase to the appropriate box.

Objective	Subjective
large significant It is necessary to consider ...	quite huge We need to derive the balance equation. Let's look at ...

Submit

You have used 3 of 5 attempts.

 Reset

 Show Answer

FEEDBACK

✓ Correctly placed 7 items.

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Formal language

Formal language is one way to distinguish a scientific report from a friendly conversation about your research. The words used should be precise, not overly colloquial and not abbreviated. To achieve this style, focus on the following aspects:

- Once again, avoid the words "I" and "you" in the text, and use "we" only sparingly.
- When referring to another author, do not use first names.
- Be precise in your word choices. You should avoid vague statements such as "kind of" or "a bit". For verb choices, choose a verb like "investigate" or "study" rather than the broader term "look at". Likewise, it is more precise to say you "calculate" or "estimate" a constant, instead of "getting" it.
(Note: This requirement of precision does not mean that long, or complicated words are to be preferred over short ones.)
- Avoid colorful or flowery language. The sentence "Let's face the music and start calculating" is overly colloquial and does not belong in a research report. Similarly, it would be informal to refer to your figure as "incredibly beautiful".
- Avoid contractions: Write "cannot", "will not", and "it is" rather than "can't", "won't" and "it's".
- Avoid excess words that are often used in spoken sentences, such as "just", "simply", or "quite". These words do not add anything to the meaning of your text.

The concepts mentioned here are clearly related to objectivity. Many of the examples given are both informal and subjective. Since you need to avoid both informal and subjective words, this should not be a problem.

Exercise B

1/1 point (graded)

 Keyboard Help

PROBLEM

Please determine which of the following words and phrases are formal, and which are informal. Drag each word or phrase to the appropriate box.

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Formal	Informal
a significant increase The advantages are ...	a mountain of constants Let's calculate the balance equation. The number of rainbowfish goes down fast The pros and cons of ... The gourami population doesn't grow.

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You have used 2 of 5 attempts.



Reset

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FEEDBACK

✓ Correctly placed 7 items.

✓ Good work! You have now seen some examples of formal and informal word choices.

✓ Your highest score is 1.0

A word of warning on long sentences

After all this focus on formal and objective word choices, you may get the feeling that using plain and simple words and sentences is not good enough. This is not the case. An

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On the next page, you'll learn why and how you should use references in a report.

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English ▼

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